THE SLOW MARCH TO KABUL

In 1581 two brothers, kings both, faced each other across the icy Jhelum over the fate of Kabul, ancient capital of Babur. Outside the city was Akbar, thirty-nine years old, leading an imperial army of 50,000 cavalry, 500 elephants, camel corps, and infantry. Facing him was Mirza Hakim, twenty-eight years old, and self-proclaimed guardian of the luminous Chaghatai–Timurid legacy of Babur. Mirza Hakim had spent decades cultivating that legacy, upholding the Turco–Mongol code, and paying ostentatious reverence to Babur's tomb in Kabul. According to Munis Faruqui he 'portrayed himself as a Ghazi with a rough and ready Turkish steppe identity, staunch Sunni and a bold risk taker like Babur'. Now he made an audacious appeal to the Central Asian noblemen within the Padshah's besieging army at Kabul, urging them to turn on their fellow soldiers, the 'natives of Hindustan' (Hindi nazhadan), and to join him instead, the true heir of Babur. But Akbar's troops, including 'Mongols, some Persians, some Turkmen, Chagatai, Uzbegs, Kandaharis, Baluchis, Pathans, Indians and Gujaratis, Musulmans and also Hindus' were unimpressed. Akbar, too, had spent decades preparing for just such a challenge and had wrought an empire from a careful balancing act between the various clans in it. Aziz Koka, having long outlived his milk brother, would tell Jahangir about his father's strategy: 'His Majesty Akbar during the fifty years of his reign increased the number of Chaghatais and Rajputs among nobles for these people are not seditious. They know nothing but loyalty.'

Mirza Hakim had finally laid bare his ambitions to challenge his half-brother the Padshah the previous year in December 1580 when he had marched into Hindustan and invaded the Punjab, encouraged by the mutinies in Bengal and Bihar and the rallying of orthodox Islamic elements to his banner. Akbar had then decided to finally confront his brother's claims, born of their shared legacy as Timurid mirzas, and their unshakeable belief in their right to rule. In February 1581, almost a year before the brothers would eventually face each other across the Jhelum, Akbar decided to march to Kabul. But this would not be an intemperate and blistering campaign. This would be a spectacle on the move, a glorious cavalcade